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Theorizing Adaptation in the Twenty-First Century

The Rise of Adaptation Studies

While literature-and-film studies predominated in the 1970s, with adaptation typically featuring as its most denigrated sub-category, interest in adaptation increased in the 1980s and 1990s. By 2006, the ratio of general literature-and-film studies to literary film adaptation studies had changed decisively. In that year, Andrew Higson announced: “It is adaptations . . . that dominate the literature/film relationship” (62). More broadly, my introduction to this book indicates that, of the 25,241 hits produced by entering “adaptation” as a subject term (including fields beyond literature and film), 13,903 were published after 1990 and 11,145 after 2000 (to 2018).¹

The titles of twenty-first-century literature-and-film studies publications also indicate the rise of adaptation. Robert Stam and Alessandra Raengo’s edited collection *Literature and Film* (2005a) bears the subtitle *A Guide to the Theory and Practice of Film Adaptation*; James M. Welsh and Peter Lev’s pedagogical work, *The Literature/Film Reader* (2007), is similarly subtitled *Issues of Adaptation*; John M. Desmond and Peter Hawkes’s pedagogical essay collection inverts the terms in its title, *Adaptation: Studying Film and Literature* (2006, reprinted 2015). The three terms unite in the main title of Deborah Cartmell’s edited collection, *A Companion to Literature, Film, and Adaptation* (2012).

In the twenty-first century, adaptation publications have expanded beyond literature and film to consider other media. While my history attests that adaptation in other media has been studied for centuries, what changed in the twenty-first century was that adaptation studies began to be a diasporic field encompassing many media and disciplines, rather than a sub-field discussed separately within disciplines. The two 2005 essay collections co-edited by Stam and Raengo extend adaptation scholarship to new media, including the internet, CDs, DVDs, electronic games,

interactive installations, and virtual environments, while also expanding adaptation studies of older media, including adaptation and the oral tradition, the Bible, history, photography, portraiture, early cinema, and musicals, and carrying adaptation studies beyond Anglophone works to Italy, France, China, India, and Africa. Although other scholars had treated other media and non-Anglophone adaptations for centuries, bringing the adaptations of many media and nations together in a single volume announced adaptation studies as an interdisciplinary, international field. Structuralism and cultural studies had prepared the way for such expansion and integration theoretically.

A year later, Linda Hutcheon's *A Theory of Adaptation* authoritatively declared adaptation studies open to

not just films and stage productions but also musical arrangements and song covers, visual art revisitations of prior works and comic book versions of history, poems put to music and remakes of films, and video games and interactive art. (2006, 9)

More pertinent to the arguments of my book, Hutcheon insisted:

Videogames, theme park rides, Web sites, graphic novels song covers, operas, musicals, ballets, and radio and stage plays are . . . as important to . . . theorizing as . . . the more commonly discussed movies and novels. (2006, xiv)

Since then, entire books have been devoted to adaptation in new media (e.g., Constandinides 2010; Urrows 2008; Gratch 2017), and the intermedial and multimedial adaptations of global franchise entertainment industries have been studied (Parody 2011; Elliott 2014a; Meikle 2019a). New media platforms that allow non-professionals to disseminate their adaptations widely (e.g., fan fiction, online videos, and music remixes) have carried the production of adaptation beyond mainstream adaptation industries (Martin 2009; Marlow 2009; Horwatt 2009; Moore 2010; O'Flynn 2013; Gratch 2017; Blackwell 2018). While scholars have continued to broaden adaptation studies nationally (e.g., Dovey 2009; Gordon 2009; Deppman 2010; Rentschler [1986] 2015; Gelder and Whelehan 2016) and to consider cross-cultural adaptation (e.g., Zhen 2005; O'Thomas 2010; Della Coletta 2012; Smith 2016; Stam 2017), studies of global adaptation have also emerged (Davison and Mulvey-Roberts 2018; Krasilovsky 2018; Yang and Xiaotian 2019).

By the late 2010s, major adaptation studies were dropping literature and film from their titles, most notably *The Oxford Handbook of Adaptation Studies* (Leitch 2017a) and *The Routledge Companion to Adaptation* (Cutchins, Krebs, and Voigts 2018). These edited collections contain chapters on theatrical adaptation, adaptation and illustration, adaptation and opera, popular song and adaptation, radio adaptation, comic-book adaptation, videogame adaptation, adaptation and social media, adaptation and new media, and adaptation and remix culture, as well as chapters studying the relationship between adaptation and history and adaptation and politics. However, literature and film continue to feature prominently in their tables of contents and remain central to adaptation studies today, as the titles and tables of contents of the field's three journals, *Literature/Film Quarterly*, *Adaptation: The Journal of Literature on Screen*, and the *Journal of Adaptation in Film & Performance* also attest.²

The Theoretical Turn in Adaptation Studies

Although the theories of the theoretical turn were applied to adaptation from the 1970s, the theoretical turn did not enter the adaptation studies mainstream until the turn of the twentieth century (1996–2005). It did so in a bifurcated way: there was a postmodern cultural, radical political theoretical turn in Britain and a quasi-poststructuralist formal and semiotic theoretical turn in the United States. In spite of their division along cultural and formal lines, poststructuralist and postmodern theorists allied in rejecting aesthetic formalism, New Criticism, and high-art humanism, while positions on structuralist semiotics and narratology varied.

In Britain, Deborah Cartmell, Imelda Whelehan, Ian Q. Hunter, Heidi Kaye, and contributors to their seven essay collections (1996–2001) championed postmodern cultural studies. In addition to *Pulping Fictions* (1996), discussed at the end of Chapter 3, they published:

Trash Aesthetics: Popular Culture and Its Audience (Pluto, 1997)

Sisterhoods across the Literature/Media Divide (Pluto, 1998)

Alien Identities: Exploring Differences in Film and Fiction (Pluto, 1999)

Classics in Film and Fiction (Pluto, 2000)

Adaptations: From Text to Screen, Screen to Text (Routledge, 1999)

Retrovisions: Reinventing the Past in Film and Fiction (Pluto, 2001)³

Both *Pulping Fictions* and *Trash Culture* engage postmodern and left-wing political theories to challenge divisions between high and low culture in literature, film, and adaptation. The introduction to *Classics in Film and Fiction* draws on Pierre Bourdieu's political theory of cultural capital to argue that "a belief in 'classics' superior to other works reproduces . . . hierarchical society and its power," and that what constitutes a classic is not a merely a matter of aesthetic formalism "but rather a highly politicized issue," with "both classroom and social class . . . implied in . . . the term 'classic'" (2000, 3).

The introduction to *Retrovisions* establishes the collection's postmodern view of history as nonlinear, subjective, relative, and constructed, often as a coercive discourse of power, requiring postmodern skepticism and radical political critique to challenge and dismantle its authority (2001, 1–2). In these marriages of postmodern philosophy and radical politics, left-wing ideologies and values predominate over philosophical skepticism and ecumenical pluralism. *Pulping Fictions* attacks high culture and valorizes low culture; *Classics in Film and Fiction* challenges the canon and high-art humanism; *Trash Culture* analyzes low adaptations of high culture to subvert the canon; *Sisterhoods* reads literature, film, and adaptation via feminist and queer theories; *Aliens* engages the extra-terrestrial and non-human to probe the politics of "class, race, gender, nationality, and sexual orientation" (1999, 3).

Formal adaptation studies also underwent a theoretical turn, led by American film scholars James Naremore, Robert B. Ray, Robert Stam, and Thomas Leitch. At the turn of the millennium, Ray mounted an influential theoretical critique of "the field of literature and film," then still synonymous with adaptation studies,⁴ contending that the field floundered and was marginalized by literary studies and film studies alike because it lacked "a presiding poetics" (2000, 44), because it used adaptation studies "to shore up literature's crumbling walls" against the rising tide of film and popular culture (46), and because it functioned as a bastion of resistance to the theoretical turn in the humanities. The belatedness of the theoretical turn in adaptation studies led Ray to describe the field as "ultimately antitheoretical," "thoroughly discredited," and "irrelevant" (45–46), and Leitch to charge that "adaptation theory [had] remained tangential to the thrust of film study because it [had] never been undertaken with conviction and theoretical rigor" but had been "practiced in a theoretical vacuum" (2003a, 168).

Even so, Ray acknowledged that "the field of literature and film was not without paradigm. . . . [I]t inherited the assumptions of the dominant New

Criticism" (44–45). For Ray, "the New Criticism proved ultimately antitheoretical" (2000, 45); for Leitch in 2003, central tenets of medium specificity theory, Romanticism, aesthetic formalism, and New Criticism constituted "fallacies in contemporary adaptation theory" (2003a, essay title).⁵ Leitch argued for institutional as well as theoretical change, advocating the establishment of "Textual Studies, a discipline incorporating adaptation study, cinema studies in general, and literary studies" (2003a, 42), a reorganization that would simultaneously affirm the intertextual theories that he recommended for retheorizing the field and diminish uses of adaptation studies to foster disciplinary rivalries by housing media under a single discipline.

Also in the 2000s, Stam recommended that Bakhtinian dialogics replace New Critical organic unity, word and image divides, Marxist dialectics, and structuralist binaries and that scholars engage poststructuralist theory to deconstruct notions of originals and copies and to challenge one-way translation methodologies in adaptation studies, as well as to subvert linear, progressive, evolutionary histories of media forms and adaptation. He further contested Romantic and modernist auteur theories with Barthes's death of the author and Foucault's discursive constructionism (2000; 2005). My own *Rethinking the Novel/Film Debate* (2003a) is also indebted to Foucault's theories of discourse. Its attempts to re-historicize and retheorize literature–film relations (including adaptation) combined linear historical study with New Historicism and metacritical discourse analysis with cognitive linguistics to rethink adaptation studies, as well as novel-and-film studies more generally.

In contrast to Ray, Cartmell, Whelehan, and their co-editors and contributors did not view high-art humanism, aesthetic formalism, and New Criticism to be "irrelevant" but to exert formidable cultural, social, political clout in academia and culture, fostering unjust and oppressive social, media, political, cultural, and academic hierarchies that required dismantling by postmodern theories and revolutionizing by radical political ones. Despite their differences, both groups shared a progressivist view of theorization: although they disagreed on which new theories and methodologies were needed for the field to progress, they agreed that using the "right" new theories would resolve the problems of theorizing adaptation brought about by the "wrong" old theories. Straddling as it does so many media, disciplines, and cultures, and, being itself antithetical to humanities theorization, adaptation served as an incisive and powerful case study for these revolutionary

theoretical endeavors. What we did not see then was that the problem of theorizing adaptation was a systemic one based in dissonance between adaptation and theorization as cultural processes in the humanities that could not be resolved by changing old theories for new: we needed a revolution in what theorization is and does in the humanities and in its relationship to adaptation, as well as to what it theorizes more generally.

By 2005, most of the theories pioneered by turn-of-the-century scholars had been applied to adaptation substantially in works published by mainstream academic presses. In that year, Robert Stam wrote and co-edited three volumes expanding and synthesizing the field of adaptation. The monograph *Literature through Film: Realism, Magic, and the Art of Adaptation* (Stam 2004) offers a theoretical history of literary film adaptation departed from prior histories by following the history of the novel rather than the history of film. Reading film adaptations as interpretations of the works they adapt, it puts film adaptation on a par with literary criticism. Stam's authoritative and polemical introduction to the second work, an edited collection titled *Literature and Film: A Guide to the Theory and Practice of Film Adaptation* (Stam and Raengo 2005a), benefits from his expansive knowledge of film, media, and literary theories, providing an incisive metacritical analysis of adaptation's relationship to other field histories and theories, diagnosing and recommending ways to redress adaptation's theoretical problems, and deftly integrating formal and cultural aspects of the theoretical turn, as well as adaptation theory and adaptation practice. The third volume, *A Companion to Literature and Film* (Stam and Raengo 2005b) expands adaptation studies still further. Beyond their role in expanding and rendering adaptation's disciplines, nations, and media, the three volumes are *theoretically* pluralistic, engaging theories of comparative narratology, intertextuality, adaptive phenomenology, psychology, transécriture and narrative mediatics, theologies of adaptation, social discourse theory, sociology, cultural materialism, queer theory, and of nation and race.

In *Adaptation and Appropriation* (2006), Julie Sanders too engages both formal and cultural aspects of the theoretical turn, bringing "structuralism, post-structuralism, postcolonialism, postmodernism, feminism and gender studies" to bear upon adaptation (publisher's blurb), while in 2005, contributors to Mireia Aragay's edited collection *Books in Motion: Adaptation, Intertextuality, Authorship* (2005a) applied poststructuralist intertextuality, postcolonialism, feminism, postmodernism, and dialogics blended with psychoanalysis to adaptation, along with essays

rethinking fidelity and auteur theories. The field was becoming theoretically pluralistic, a product of postmodern theory; the following year would witness the publication of a formidably pluralistic theoretical monograph. But it would also demonstrate staunch resistance to the theoretical turn in adaptation studies.

Formal and Cultural Theoretical Wars in Adaptation Studies

Adaptation scholars were by no means agreed on the theoretical turn. The year 2006 was not only the year in which Higson affirmed the predominance of adaptation in literature-and-film studies; it also witnessed the publication of two monographs indicating ongoing theoretical divides between form and cultural adaptation studies and between pre- and post-theoretical turn theories: Linda Costanzo Cahir's *Literature into Film: Theory and Practical Approaches* and Linda Hutcheon's *A Theory of Adaptation*. While in 1996 the incipient cultural studies collective had been more oppositional and the established formal scholar more ecumenical, these roles reversed in 2006 as the theoretical turn became more established and older theories became less mainstream. Cahir's study is more hostile to and exclusive of cultural studies than McFarlane's was in 1996, opening with a virulent polemic against the theoretical turn by James M. Welsh, co-founder of *LFQ* and the Literature/Film Association. In 1996, Cahir worked as hard to carve out separate spheres for older formal and newer cultural adaptation studies as prior scholars had done to separate literature from film. Against poststructuralist and postmodern cultural attacks on comparative translation methodologies, Cahir advocated restoring "translation" as the primary field terminology, displacing "adaptation":

"To adapt" means to alter the structure or function of an entity so that it is better fitted to survive and to multiply in its new environment. . . . "To translate," in contrast to "to adapt," is to move a text from one language to another. It is a *process of language*, not a process of survival and generation. (2006, 14, emphasis in original)

Understanding that adaptation, as a process of changing something to suit a new environment, requires attention to cultural contexts, Cahir sought to

redefine the field as a purely formal field of intermedial translation. This argument threatened the survival of adaptation as a field of study.

By contrast, Hutcheon argued that translation approaches are inadequate for theorizing adaptation (16–18). Building on the theories of Roland Barthes, Hutcheon argued that narratives are both cultural and formal constructs and that the two cannot be separated. She also understood that other media forms are just as much contexts for adaptation as the cultural contexts that we more commonly nominate as such. Hutcheon extended postmodern diversity and pluralism from subject matter to *theories*, granting space in her monograph for theories that other postmodern cultural scholars would later advocate discarding (Cartmell and Whelehan 2010). Even so, her expansion of adaptation studies to all manner of media and her inclusion of popular culture implicitly, and decisively, rejected the high-art aesthetic theories that exclude such works from scholarship. Ecumenism, then, can refute theoretical principles as well as support them. Additionally, her insistence that adaptation must be defined in terms of reception as well as production (15–16) challenged the priority of author intent and adapter agency in formal studies, priorities that were the main focus of aesthetic formalist adaptation studies. Five years on, Colin MacCabe insisted that “how and why filmmakers adapt books and what they did to adapt them” remained central to adaptation studies (2011, 7). As Cahir opposed cultural theories of adaptation at the level of field definition, MacCabe opposed them at the level of methodological taxonomies. Contracting the chapter titles ordering Hutcheon’s theoretical work—Who? What? How? Why? When? Where?—to “how,” “why,” and “what” eradicates the “where” and “when” that are the main focus of cultural and contextual studies.

While Cahir’s work garnered respect, Hutcheon’s *A Theory of Adaptation* became the most cited tome in adaptation studies, cited 4024 times by comparison to 155 citations of Cahir’s book.⁶ However, Amazon sales rankings reveal a resounding reversal in the economies of the academic adaptation industry: Hutcheon’s book ranks 11,640,936 and Cahir’s 914,326,⁷ suggesting that Cahir’s book has been used more in adaptation pedagogy by scholars who teach, while Hutcheon’s has been used more by scholars who publish.⁸ Pricing must play a role in sales (Cahir’s is more affordable than Hutcheon’s across all platforms), and sales rankings change over time, so that it is impossible to know whether Hutcheon’s sold better at other times. Both books have been reprinted: Hutcheon’s 2012 second edition stands at 3,408,133 in Amazon’s sales rankings; Cahir’s 2014 reprint has not been differentiated

from the first print run. The wider total circulation of Cahir's book helps to explain why older theories persist in adaptation studies, proliferate in media industries, and among the general public.

Tensions between formal and cultural theories of adaptation continued, with variations, culminating in another pair of books published one year apart: Cartmell and Whelehan's *Screen Adaptation: Impure Cinema* (2010) and MacCabe, Warner, and Murray's *True to the Spirit: Film Adaptation and the Question of Fidelity* (2011). Both books share an interest in defending adaptation from charges of secondariness: Cartmell and Whelehan continued their longstanding commitment to rescuing adaptation from high-art, humanist contempt in their book, while MacCabe resisted the prioritization of literature over film in adaptation, calling for equality between adapted literature and adapting films, in his introduction to the edited collection (MacCabe 2011, 8). Yet they disagreed theoretically. In 1999, Whelehan had been confident that "a cultural studies approach foregrounds the activities of reception and consumption, and shelves—forever perhaps—considerations of the aesthetic or cultural worthiness of the object of study" (18). Yet, finding that such considerations had not been shelved over a decade on, she and co-author Cartmell expressed perplexity at their persistence, describing them as "a small body of work moving against the main tide of theory . . . an attitude to adaptations . . . that refuses to go away" (2010, 11). It may have been small body of work when Cartmell and Whelehan's book went to press; however, in the year their book was published it was outnumbered by aesthetic formalist publications.⁹

The following year, MacCabe responded in print: "The fact is that people are still interested in how and why filmmakers adapt books and what they did to adapt them. So these issues and questions are not going to *go away* and perhaps it is time to ask why it is that we refuse to address them" (2011, 7, emphasis added). MacCabe not only defended his interest in aesthetic and practitioner adaptation studies, he also attacked theoretical rejections of them: "academic abandonment of questions of value is not simply theoretically ignorant but also practically disastrous" (9). To be fair, Cartmell and Whelehan have manifested longstanding interest in adaptation practitioners, most notably television adapter Andrew Davies, hosting him and others at conferences, and publishing articles by practitioners in the journal they edit, *Adaptation*. The opposition is not one between theory and practice, nor between maintaining and abandoning values generally, but between the values of high-art humanism and left-wing cultural studies.

Puzzlingly, given that his theories are older than theirs, MacCabe charged his opponents with theoretical superannuation: “Adaptation studies, rather like Don Quixote, continue to fight the day before yesterday’s battles” (7). Yet the charge is not that cultural studies adaptation scholars adhere to theories older than his own, but that they continue to fight theoretical battles in the 2010s that were fought in other fields in the 1980s and 1990s. MacCabe’s view is that older theories survived the theoretical turn, and will continue to survive, so that these battles are no longer worth fighting because he will never concede to the turn. Yet battles over cultural values are not only yesterday’s battles, they are also today’s and tomorrow’s battles: as in politics, they will continue to be fought by scholars as long as there is one opponent left standing.

Although Cartmell and Whelehan’s co-authored book was published by a well-regarded academic press, Palgrave, and although they edit the Oxford journal *Adaptation*, MacCabe’s co-edited collection was published by Oxford University Press, its prestige heightened by essays from internationally renowned scholars Dudley Andrew, Laura Mulvey, Tom Gunning, and Fredric Jameson. Once again, the reception of the two books divides: as of December 23, 2019, MacCabe’s book had been cited 80 times to 158 for Cartmell and Whelehan’s book (Google Scholar), while it ranked above theirs in sales (1,657,007 in Amazon sales rankings to their 1,930,308 ranking).¹⁰ However, the gap in sales is narrower than a decade before, indicating the ascendancy of cultural adaptation studies.

Cartmell and Whelehan’s theories were under attack from within the contextual adaptation studies camp as well. In 2008, and again in 2012, Simone Murray forged a wider rift than the longstanding ones running between literature and film and between modernist formal and postmodern cultural theories, opposing humanities methodologies and theories with those of the social sciences. Objecting to textual studies of all kinds, including radical political and poststructuralist textual studies, Murray too sought to “shelve” prior theories: “Adaptation studies urgently needs . . . to *move out from under* the aegis of long-dominant formalist and textual analysis traditions . . . and *instead* begin to understand adaptation sociologically” (2008, 10, emphasis added). The argument is not for the theoretical and methodological supplementation or expansion advocated by Hutcheon, but one of removal and usurpation. Placing textual studies of all kinds into one group, Murray asserted that poststructuralist advocate and dialogician Robert Stam had “merely closed the circle” on more than 50 years of textual adaptation studies

inaugurated by aesthetic formalist George Bluestone (2008, 5). Few would agree with this view; Stam engaged dialogics, reader response theory, and poststructuralism to open up textual studies from New Critical analyses of closed organic wholes and binary, chronological comparisons of two media forms.

The social sciences methodologies recommended by Murray have indubitably informed, developed, and supplemented adaptation studies. Even so, annihilating textual studies seems too much like a “final solution” from the social sciences for humanities adaptation studies. Moreover, it excludes essential aspects of humanities adaptation from study. As a process by which texts adapt or are adapted to new contexts, humanities adaptation studies requires consideration of both texts and contexts. Texts and contexts are not antonyms: texts are embedded in the word “contexts,” indicating their inextricability, and the etymology of “con” here hails from “connect,” meaning “with,” not “contrary,” meaning “against.”

One of the many reasons that Cartmell and Whelehan have been recognized as field leaders is that, for all their protests against high-art formalism, their writings maintain focus on both textual *and* contextual factors in adaptation. Indeed, far from being offended by Murray’s critique of textual cultural studies, Cartmell responded positively with an industry-based study of *Adaptations in the Sound Era, 1927–37* (2015), and went further to argue that “New scholars . . . should . . . reflect on the commercial and material conditions (rather than a single literary text) as what *really* underpins the field” (2017, n.p., emphasis added). Concomitantly, Leitch has observed that Murray herself undertakes textual readings in her monograph (2018, 700).

Stepping back from the adaptation industry to ponder the academic industry, championing industry studies as the only valid or “real” form of adaptation scholarship does not take sufficiently into account the economic and class hierarchies within academia. The archival research required to produce Murray’s and Cartmell’s impressive case studies requires substantial funding and ample leave from teaching and administration duties, as the acknowledgments to both books attest: only a handful of fortunate scholars have access to such resources.¹¹ Textual study, by contrast, is available to every scholar.

Championing one theoretical position and opposing others is endemic to theorization and academic study; yet in the multidisciplinary field of adaptation studies, seeking to do away with theories has indubitably occluded vital aspects of adaptation. Such a diverse field as adaptation studies

benefits from diversity not only in its subject matter but also in its theories and methodologies. The preface to *A Theory of Adaptation* underscores Hutcheon's remarkable theoretical ecumenism, one that extends to theories that other postmodern scholars oppose: "At various times . . . I take on the roles of formalist semiotician, poststructuralist deconstructor, or feminist and postcolonial demythifier" (2006, xii). Inevitably, her work has been castigated by scholars who want her to take sides in the theoretical wars or to produce a definitive theory that refutes all the rest. Fellow postmodernists Cartmell and Whelehan view her book as a failed attempt at Grand Theory, criticizing her for making the attempt: "the attempt to answer what, who, why, how,¹² and where coupled with the dizzying number of examples provided in the book point to the conclusion that there cannot be, as the title promises, *a* theory of adaptation" (2010, 56, emphasis in original). Yet Hutcheon's preface cautions against such interpretations of her book: "*A Theory of Adaptation* is quite simply what its title says it is: one single attempt to think through some of the theoretical issues surrounding the ubiquitous phenomenon of adaptation *as adaptation*" (2006, xvi, emphasis in original). It is *a* theory, not *the* theory of adaptation—a postmodern pastiche of many theories.

Other scholars have been disappointed by Hutcheon's refusal to offer *the* definitive theory of adaptation. Heidi Peeters lauds Hutcheon as "one of the most prolific thinkers of our time . . . active and successful within various domains of the humanities," but adds: "somewhat disappointingly, *A Theory of Adaptation* does not offer the Grand Theory we might have been hoping for"; "there are no great answers in this publication, no paradigm shifts in conceptualizing adaptations," only "hundreds of lively examples" and "energetically scattered insights mixed with pieces of an overview of what has been said within the adaptational field so far" (2007, n.p.). Hutcheon's commitment to postmodern philosophy means that she has also disappointed systematic, empirical scholars for whom her subheadings (Who? What? Why? When? Where?) should have created a totalizing, factual, empirically verifiable, reproducible theory of adaptation. Instead, her book pursues a localized, pluralistic empiricism, offering many answers to the Who? What? Why? When? Where? questions from many theoretical purviews. Rather than imposing theory upon her investigations, her book seeks to "derive theory from practice" (cf. Elliott 2003a, 6) by "teas[ing] out the theoretical implications from multiple textual examples" (2006, xii). Hutcheon's book resists top-down theorization: "at no time do I (at least consciously) try to

impose any of these theories on my examination of the texts or the general issues surrounding adaptation” (2006, xii).

Although Hutcheon is more theoretically ecumenical than any other adaptation scholar I have read, she has been critiqued for short-changing theoretical approaches that she considers to be overdone. Suzanne Diamond finds that “the most provocative and generative questions that one might pose in a film course are matters Hutcheon leaves untheorized: whether a differently told story is, in fact, ‘the same’ story; where ‘difference’ and ‘sameness’ inhere among stories; and who is authorized to establish these distinctions” (2010, 96). Hutcheon intended this: “What I do want to get away from is just comparing the source text to the adaptation—doing ‘this’ is like ‘that’—going back and forth. I think that’s not useful and yet most of the work done on adaptation” does this (Zaiontz 2009, 1). Even so, her interest lay more in moving “away from” theories and methodologies that she considered to have been overdone than in returning to resolve their unresolved theoretical problems and answer their unanswered theoretical questions, an undertaking that my book can only make a small start upon.

Leitch has nominated Hutcheon’s *A Theory of Adaptation* “a theory of theories” (2013a, 159). Yet Hutcheon does not grant all theories equal space and time or present them as they have been presented by their proponents. The very act of placing theories claiming to be universal in a theoretical pastiche along with other theories undermines their totalizing claims and positions them within a larger master narrative of postmodern pluralist theory, which the proponents of universal theory ardently oppose. *A Theory of Adaptation* is not a theory that weaves theories into a coherent whole, or one that attempts to adjudicate or resolve their debates, or one that knits them into a complex metacritical nexus: the postmodern philosophy that governs the book allows theories to coexist without integration, congruity, debate, or rational cohesion. However, for those who believe that reasoning, consistency, and logic are essential for any theory to attain the status of theory, for those who believe that some theories are right (correct, true, ethical, salutary) and others are wrong (incorrect, fallacious, unethical, pernicious) and that it is the task of scholars to adjudicate these differences, Hutcheon’s theory of theories is unsatisfying. For many, placing empiricism (Who? What? Why? When? Where?) in the service of postmodern skepticism is philosophically jarring. Yet as much as they may seem philosophically and methodologically opposed, postmodern indeterminacy and empirical objectivism share a rejection of didactic, a priori value judgments in favor of open-ended questions

and the free play of ideas and, as I argue subsequently, incongruously hybrid theorization has been more successful in theorizing adaptation than unified, rational, logical theorization. Angeliqe Chettiparamb has argued that “innovation is most likely to happen in the hybrid zone; academics working [in interdisciplinary fields] can easily become ‘hybrid critics’ as they look back with fresh insights at their parent discipline and identify lacunae and gaps” (2007, 7). Indeed, one of the reasons that postmodernism has been invaluable for adaptation studies is that it reveals connections that were invisible to logical, chronological, systematic structures.

Where my study departs from Hutcheon’s is in considering theoretical relationships—their debates, wars, and alliances. As I do, I engage theoretical methodologies developed by others: aspects of dialectics and dialogics, traditional and New Historicism, discourse analysis, and rhetorical study. My study finds that the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries witnessed ongoing *alliances* forged between ideologically *opposed* theories, as well as conceptual continuities traversing otherwise differing theories. Systematic formalist theorists joined leftist cultural scholars to combat aesthetic formalism on different—even opposed—ideological grounds: systematic theorists such as McFarlane rejected theories of aesthetic value for lacking objectivity and empirical evidence, while postmodern cultural scholars such as Cartmell and Whelehan rejected them because of their implications in conservative politics. Conversely, cultural scholars, for all their ideological disagreements with aesthetic formalists, allied with them against objectivist, empirical, and systematic theories, declaring their inadequacy for explicating the “higher” values that have been, whether political or aesthetic, the *raison d’être* of most humanities studies. In a third crossover alliance that protests against making political value the focus of academic study, aesthetic formalists such as MacCabe allied with systematic theorists such as Patrick Cattrysse to argue that the focus of adaptation studies should rest on aesthetic value, not political ideologies. In a fourth transtheoretical coalition, polysystems theorist Cattrysse joined with postmodern theorists against purist formalism in demanding attention to contextual factors; both rejected unilateral attention to a single adaptation’s reworking of a single source text in favor of studying multiple textual sources and multiple contextual influences, including legal, industry, economic, pedagogical, and reception factors. In a fifth allied opposition, formalist translation scholars and postcolonial theorists expanded intercultural adaptation studies, with publications treating adaptation in Ireland, Australia, Canada, South America, France,

Germany, Spain, Italy, Greece, Canada, Japan, Egypt, Taiwan, Iran, and other Arabic-speaking nations (see the *MLA International Bibliography*). These continue in twenty-first-century publications seeking to forge connections between adaptation studies and translation studies (Gambier and Gottlieb 2001; Zatlin 2005; Milton 2009; O'Thomas 2010; Raw 2012; Krebs 2012; 2013; Minier 2013; Cattrysse 2014; Raw 2017). Clearly, divisions between theoretical camps do not run along decisive, consistent philosophical or ideological lines, but intertangle. This is also the case in negotiations between theoretical progressivism and theoretical return within adaptation studies.

Theoretical Progressivism and Theoretical Return

In 2018, Sarah Cardwell reflected:

Adaptation studies appears to be flourishing. International academic interest in the field is lively. Yet, although it is tempting to press ever onwards in the current path, it is often valuable briefly to pause and reflect. (14)

Since the incipient influx of the theoretical turn into adaptation studies in the 1970s, the field has been marked by tensions between theoretical progressivism and theoretical return. These tensions are only partially explicated by conservative resistance to the theoretical turn. There are other factors, including the failure of newer theories to resolve the problems of older ones for adaptation, tensions between neo-theorization and post-theorization, and changes in individual theorists over time. More fundamentally, since adaptation is a process of both progress and return, it has *itself* encouraged alternations between looking forward and back, adapting theory to itself.

Wars between theoretical conservatives and theoretical progressives go some way toward explicating tensions between theoretical progress and return in adaptation studies, but they do not tell the whole story. When the theoretical turn entered the humanities, hitherto dominant theories experienced a marginalization similar to that which they had formerly levied upon adaptation. Previously, they had marginalized adaptation for violating their theories; now, scholars who did not wish to adapt to new theoretical environments embraced adaptation as theoretical kin, at odds with mainstream humanities theorization. These scholars understood that, just as adaptation enables older narratives to survive (Hutcheon 2006, 32), it also enables older

theories to survive. Adaptation itself answers Cartmell and Whelehan's question as to why older theories have not "gone away": as adaptation infuses theorization, theoretical return persists along with theoretical progressivism within adaptation studies. These dynamics also answer MacCabe's question as to why radical scholars continue to engage in older theoretical debates.

Table 4.1, generated by a subject term search of the *MLA International Bibliography* for "adaptation" combined with a subject term search by theorist name, indicates the presence of both older and newer theorists in adaptation studies.¹³

Older theorists feature prominently. Classical theorists (Aristotle; Plato) appear on the table, along with neoclassicist Dryden and the nineteenth-century philosopher Kant. Modernists (Bazin; Bluestone; Sartre; Warren) outnumber postmodernists (Hutcheon). Classical psychological theorists (Freud; Jung) feature more than twice as often as poststructuralist psychoanalysts (Lacan; Mulvey); classical cultural and political theorists (Lévi-Strauss; Marx; Benjamin; Durkheim; Adorno) similarly eclipse newer ones (Bourdieu; Said); poststructuralist theorists feature in 20 entries (Kristeva; Derrida), while structuralist theorists (Barthes; Genette; Lévi-Strauss; McFarlane; Peirce) appear in nearly double that number. While Mikhail Bakhtin and Gilles Deleuze top the table, their major works were published in the 1970s–1990s. The essays comprising Bakhtin's *The Dialogic Imagination* (1981) were written in the 1930s and 1940s and brought into adaptation studies by Robert Stam in 2000. Deleuze's second spot arises more from his prominence in film studies than in adaptation studies: only 1 of the 36 publications makes adaptation its main focus, by contrast to 9 of the 38 publications in which Bakhtin features. Bakhtin remains resonant in adaptation studies because of his focus on the hybridity of language (polyglossia), the primacy of context (heteroglossia), relations between texts (intertextuality), and the cultural politics of representation, all of which remain central in adaptation studies today. Postmodern theorist Linda Hutcheon is the most prominent specifically adaptation theorist on the list.

Table 4.2, a representation of the most cited monographs in adaptation studies, shows that Hutcheon's *A Theory of Adaptation* is the most cited by a long way, in part the result of her global reputation, its title and subject matter, and its accessibility to undergraduate students. But this is also due to her theoretical hybridity and ecumenism, which answer the needs of adaptation's own hybridity and the hybridities of our diasporic field.

Table 4.1 Subject term search of the *MLA International Bibliography* for “adaptation” and theorist names

Theorist Name	No. of Citations with the Subject Term “Adaptation”
Mikhail Bakhtin	40
Gilles Deleuze	38
John Dryden	36
Walter Benjamin	27
Sigmund Freud	27
Michel Foucault	18
Linda Hutcheon	17
Gérard Genette	16
Roland Barthes	14
André Bazin	14
Carl Jung	14
Jean-Paul Sartre	14
Robert Penn Warren	13
Jacques Lacan	12
Julia Kristeva	11
Theodor Adorno	11
Judith Butler	10
Jacques Derrida	9
Edward Said	8
Aristotle	6
Plato	6
Karl Marx	5
Laura Mulvey	4
Immanuel Kant	4
George Bluestone	3
Pierre Bourdieu	3
Claude Lévi-Strauss	3
C. S. Peirce	3
Jean-François Lyotard	2
Thomas Leitch	2
Brian McFarlane	2
Julie Sanders	2
Robert Stam	2
Simone Murray	1

Note: Search date December 23, 2019.

Table 4.2 Most-cited monographs in adaptation studies

Author, Title, Date	No. of Citations
Linda Hutcheon, <i>A Theory of Adaptation</i> (2006/2012)	4024
Julie Sanders, <i>Adaptation and Appropriation</i> (2006/2017)	1658
Brian McFarlane, <i>Novel to Film</i> (1996)	1318
George Bluestone, <i>Novels into Film</i> (1957)	1202
Dudley Andrew, <i>Concepts in Film Theory*</i> (1984)	1187
Thomas Leitch, <i>Film Adaptation and Its Discontents</i> (2007)	704
Kamilla Elliott, <i>Rethinking the Novel/Film Debate</i> (2003)	541
Robert Stam, <i>Literature through Film</i> (2004)	468
Sarah Cardwell, <i>Adaptation Revisited</i> (2002)	372
Joy Boyum, <i>Double Exposure: Fiction into Film</i> (1985)	242
Simone Murray, <i>The Adaptation Industry</i> (2012a)	241
Phyllis Zatlin, <i>Theatrical Translation and Film Adaptation</i> (2005)	234
Christine Geraghty, <i>Now a Major Motion Picture</i> (2008)	230
Cartmell and Whelehan, <i>Screen Adaptation</i> (2010)	158
Linda Cahir, <i>Literature into Film</i> (2006)	155

Note: Data from Google Scholar, accessed December 23, 2019. The list of single-authored works makes an exception to include Cartmell and Whelehan's co-authored work (2010). The list excludes more specialized adaptation studies treating the adaptations of artists, nations, periods, and topics. Some of these monographs are not exclusively devoted to adaptation, but they all treat it substantially.

*This monograph contains Andrew's oft-cited chapter on adaptation; there are no separate citation counts on Google Scholar for this chapter.

It also indicates that monographs engaging the theories of the theoretical turn are more frequently cited by scholars than those pursuing pre-turn theories. That older works have had more time to be cited renders this finding all the more resonant. Table 4.3's list of adaptation studies' most cited essay collections presents a similar theoretical landscape.

However, Table 4.4's list of adaptation studies' most frequently cited articles and chapters shows that formal adaptation publications predominate over cultural ones; even so, most of these works engage the progressive formal theories of the theoretical turn rather than older formal theories. (Chatman's structuralist narratological essay is an exception.)

In spite of the preference for theoretical progress over theoretical return in scholarly citations, my introduction to this book documents an ongoing rhetoric of theoretical failure, lack, and disappointment in surveys of field theorization, even in the wake of progressive theorization. The theoretical

Table 4.3 Adaptation studies most cited edited collections

Editor(s), Title, Date	No. of Citations
Stam and Raengo, <i>Literature and Film</i> (2005)	448
James Naremore, <i>Film Adaptation</i> (2000)	454
Cartmell and Whelehan, <i>Adaptations</i> (1999)	373
Timothy Corrigan, <i>Literature and Film Reader</i> (2011)	256
Robert Richardson, <i>Literature and Film</i> (1969)	212
Cartmell and Whelehan, <i>Cambridge Companion to Literature on Screen</i> (2007)	187
Stam and Raengo, <i>A Companion to Literature and Film</i> (2005b)	171
Mireia Aragay, <i>Books in Motion</i> (2005)	146

Note: Data from Google Scholar, accessed December 23, 2019.

Table 4.4 Adaptation studies most cited essays

Author, Title, Date	No. of Citations
Robert Stam, "Beyond Fidelity: The Dialogics of Adaptation" (2000)	947
Seymour Chatman, "What Novels Can Do that Films Can't" (1980)	529
Thomas Leitch, "Twelve Fallacies in Contemporary Adaptation Theory" (2003a)	365
François Truffaut, "A Certain Tendency in French Cinema" ([1954] 1976)	337
André Bazin, "Adaptation, or the Cinema as Digest" ([1948] 2000)	229
Thomas Leitch, "Adaptation Studies at a Crossroads" (2008b)	211
James Naremore, "Film and the Reign of Adaptation" (1999)	191
Patrick Cattrysse, "Film (Adaptation) as Translation" (1992)	187
Robert B. Ray, "The Field of 'Literature and Film'" (2000)	187
John Ellis, "The Literary Adaptation" (1982)	141
Laurence Venuti, "Adaptation, Translation, Critique" (2007)	138
Brian McFarlane, "Reading Film and Literature" (2007)	111
André Bazin, "In Defense of Mixed Cinema" ([1952] 1967)	110

Note: Data from Google Scholar, accessed December 23, 2019.

turn has enriched the field, but it has not resolved adaptation's theoretical problems, nor has it ended adaptation's marginalization by single disciplines or silenced critiques of adaptation scholarship from without or within. As Ray found adaptation studies to lack "a presiding poetics" (2000, 44) and Leitch decreed the first and founding fallacy of adaptation studies to be that "there is such a thing as contemporary adaptation theory" (2003a, 149), in 2010, Brett Westbrook continued the critique, articulating it as a rupture between theorization and adaptation: "lack of theory about adaptation studies stands in direct contrast to the rise of theory in and of itself" (25). Westbrook made this claim in spite of the panoply of new theories informing adaptation before 2010 and those introduced subsequently. In 2011, Clare Parody theorized adaptation in light of franchise entertainment and new media theories. Between 2011 and 2013, Jennifer Jeffers (2011), Cristina Della Coletta (2012), and Anne-Marie Scholz (2013) theorized adaptations as cross-cultural, transnational, and historico-cultural events. In 2013, John Hodgkins brought affect theory into the field, while Kyle Meikle developed an archaeological approach to adaptation theory. In 2014, Gordon E. Slethaug raised aspects of postmodern philosophy and theory neglected by earlier postmodern political scholars, while Christophe Collard applied Bonnie Marranca's theory of mediaturgy and simultaneity to adaptation.

The year 2015 brought biopolitics (Nicklas) and new perspectives on transmediality (Straumann) and intermediality (Constantinescu) into the field, as well as a study of "History as Adaptation" (Leitch). The following year, 2016, welcomed a theory of "tradaption" (Fortier); in 2017, Cartmell theorized adaptation as exploitation; Meikle delineated a theory of adaptation audiences; and Pascal Nicklas and Arthur M. Jacobs wedded neurocognitive science to the aesthetics of adaptation. In 2018, Nicklas and Sibylle Baumbach co-edited a special issue of the journal *Adaptation* linking adaptation to perception, treating the subject with a range of theoretical perspectives from phenomenology through cognitive science to interactivity. In 2019, Kyle Meikle published a monograph treating *Adaptations in the Franchise Era: 2001–16* (2019a); Werner Schäfer and Johannes Fehle edited an essay collection examining *Adaptation in the Age of Media Convergence*; Jeremy Strong edited a special issue of the journal *Adaptation* theorizing adaptation in terms of history (2019); Eckart Voigts presented a conference paper on posthuman adaptation and digimodernism (2019); and Meikle linked film adaptation to climate adaptation through a rubric of recycling (2019b). These theories and studies are illustrative rather than exhaustive: there is no doubt

that adaptation studies has manifested theoretical and disciplinary diversity and intelligent attention to recent and current theoretical trends and issues. As I have argued, and will argue further in Part II of this book, discourses of theoretical lack continue not because adaptation studies lacks theories, or because adaptation scholars are theoretically lacking, but because *theorization* is lacking in explicating adaptation and because adaptation and theorization in the humanities continue to engage in a dysfunctional relationship. In 2015, Rainer Emig argued that adaptation studies had not yet adequately or fully engaged the canonical radical theorists of the 1960s–1990s (Derrida; Foucault; Lyotard; Kristeva; Baudrillard; Bhabba; and Butler). Emig was right. Scholars have applied these theories slimly, slightly, and loosely in isolated case studies or momentarily in pastiches of many theories.¹⁴ Although adaptation studies engages a wide range of theories, its diversity has been scattershot rather than sustained. Adaptation studies has no equivalents of film studies' extensive attention to Lacanian psychoanalytic theory or Deleuzian philosophy, nor does it have counterparts to or literary studies' sophisticated developments of deconstructive postcolonial or feminist theorization. In 2018, Sarah Cardwell assessed:

Today's apparent eclecticism and openness constitute a breadth that belies a lack of depth. There are many oversights in this new age of adaptation studies: topics that lie neglected, questions that remain buried and unanswered, and alternative approaches not yet adopted. These are the unforeseen drawbacks of the particular nature of expansion the field has undergone since the late 1990s. (7)

But another reason we have not applied theories extensively or deeply may be the failure of these theories to explicate adaptation. The theoretical turn did not resolve modernism's problems with theorizing adaptation largely because both post- and neo-theories were far more interested in adapting theorization than in theorizing adaptation. That one of the greatest theorists and thinkers of our day, Linda Hutcheon, has not theorized adaptation to the satisfaction of many scholars, including fellow postmodernists, supports my argument that there are impasses between theorization and adaptation in the humanities that progressivism in the form of new theories and theoretical pluralism have not resolved and cannot resolve. While Hutcheon's theory of postmodernism (1988) and theory of parody (1985) are highly regarded, we have seen that her theory of adaptation received mixed reviews. Scholars

may *debate* Hutcheon's theories of postmodernism and parody, including Fredric Jameson, but that discourse of *disagreement* over her other theories differs markedly from the rhetoric of *disappointment* that has characterized reviews of her theory of adaptation. Hutcheon did not theorize adaptation as satisfactorily for other scholars as she had theorized postmodernism, I argue, not because of any theoretical failure or scholarly lack on her part—indeed, her book manifests a wider range of research than any other in the field and is brimming with dazzling insights—but because adaptation as a process resists the processes of humanities theorization, as Part II of this book details. As long as that impasse remains, introducing new theories does not, therefore, resolve the problem of theorizing adaptation: indeed, creating a pastiche of many theories may even exacerbate it. What we need are not new theories of adaptation but new theories of theorization.

There are also specific theoretical reasons why the problem of theorizing adaptation has not been resolved by newer theories. Even as poststructuralism challenged structuralism and aesthetic formalism, it did not answer their unresolved questions concerning what passes in the process of adaptation or rescue adaptation from formalist and aesthetic theoretical abuse. Rather, poststructuralism exacerbated these problems. This history traces an increasing assault on adaptation by formal theories: aesthetic formalism renders separating form from content unaesthetic; structuralist semiotics renders it impossible; and poststructuralist semiotics evaporates the notion of content altogether (Elliott 2004)—so much so, that for Cardwell, (post) structuralist intertextuality “challenge[s] the very existence of the category of adaptation” (2018, 9). In so doing, it fails to explain adaptation's processes of change to suit new environments and, in its hostility to similarity, it does not theorize adaptation's repetitions. Moreover, poststructuralism *displaces* the processes of adaptation with those of deconstruction. Deconstruction and adaptation may have points in common and inform each other, but adaptation does not reduce to deconstruction. Nor did adaptation need poststructuralism to problematize its relations between originals and copies or to theorize its disruptions of hierarchical binarisms: adaptation had been doing both for centuries.

For these reasons, there have been few poststructuralist studies of adaptation; most have drawn on poststructuralism suggestively and generically (e.g., John O. Thompson 1996; Naremore 2000b; Stam 2000; Sanders [2006] 2017; Hurst 2008; Vartan 2014; Geal 2019) to dismantle adaptation's cultural and media hierarchical binarisms. Neo-translation and neo-structuralist

theories feature far more prominently in adaptation studies than post-structuralist theories, as chapters in the 2017 *Oxford Handbook* (Bal; Boozer; Elleström; Raw; M.-L. Ryan; Stam) and 2018 Routledge *Companion* (Gaudreault and Marion; Geal) attest. That one of the field's most respected scholars, Stam, made a theoretical return to structuralist and dialogical theories of intertextuality in his contribution to the 2017 *Oxford Handbook* rather than developing the poststructuralist theories he propounded more than a decade earlier supports the argument that poststructuralism has been less fruitful for explicating adaptation than structuralism. Theoretical return, then, can represent a return to theories that are more hospitable to adaptation from those that are less so.

Another reason why adaptation theorization has struggled is that, while leading twenty-first-century adaptation scholars have been ready to challenge Romantic originality with poststructuralism and postmodernism, most have not substantially challenged medium specificity theory.¹⁵ Although Hutcheon acknowledged that medium specificity is a discourse rather than a scientific fact, she presented no counterarguments to it, instead valuing it as a useful tool for studying intermedial adaptation (2006, 33 ff.). Similarly, while Stam challenged the hierarchical binarisms levied on literature and film, he subscribed to medium specificity as "The Automatic Difference" (2005, 16–24). In 2010, Christa Albrecht-Crane and Dennis R. Cutchins recommended a *return* to medium specificity theory as remedy for field marginalization:

In order to move from the fringe of critical studies and assume the more central role we believe adaptation studies can and should fulfil, a number of important ideas must be adopted. Perhaps the most significant of these is the notion that literature and cinema are radically different from each other . . . *fundamentally* different[t]. . . . [W]e are arguing for a revised approach to adaptation studies that takes into account the ways in which different media contain structures and constraints unique to a particular medium. (2010b, 13–14; 21, emphasis in original)

Since the single disciplines marginalizing adaptation studies had mostly rejected medium specificity theory by this time, the recourse to it here may be an attempt to reassure single disciplines that adaptation will not transgress their disciplinary lines.

Why medium specificity persists has more to do with institutional territoriality than with theoretical difficulties. Medium specificity theories are not

difficult to refute theoretically and have been refuted in adaptation studies via many epistemologies many times: logical reasoning (Leitch 2003a), empiricism and cognitive theory (Elliott 2003a), radical politics (Cartmell, Hunter, Kaye, and Whelehan 1996; 1997; 1998; 1998; 2000) postmodern and poststructuralist critiques (Sanders [2006] 2017; Hurst 2008), and cultural constructivism (Rajewsky 2002). But medium specificity persists, fueled by the economic interests of academic and media industries, as my history has shown.

Janus-Faced Adaptation Studies: Post-Theorization and Neo-Theorization

I have argued that a blend of theoretical progress and return may be generated in part by the exigencies of theorizing adaptation as a process of variation and return. As a result, adaptation requires what Leitch has nominated as a Janus-faced looking both back and forward (2005, 234). Adaptation's split temporality both resists and fosters theoretical progress and theoretical return, pulling away from and toward both.

But there are other reasons. When new theories fail to resolve old questions and debates, scholars return to discarded theories to determine what theoretical babies might have been thrown out with old theoretical bathwater. While most field histories and overviews construct a narrative of theoretical progress (Whelehan 1999; Ray 2000; Stam 2000; 2005; Aragay 2005b; Murray 2012a; Leitch 2017b), some have advocated theoretical return to retrieve and recuperate theories discarded by progressivists (Cahir 2006; Welsh 2007; Corrigan 2010; Andrew 2011; MacCabe 2011; Cattrysse 2014; Richard 2018). Leitch's history of adaptation studies, which moves through a pre-(film) history, 0.0, and versions 1.0, 2.0, and 3.0 spanning the late 1950s to the present, takes a progressivist path (2017b). By contrast, Timothy Corrigan, who joined Cartmell and Whelehan in calling for theoretical progress in the editorial introduction to the first issue of 2008, later advanced the value of engaging older and newer theories in tandem for contemporary adaptation studies:

We need to encourage the refractive spread of adaptation studies where evolutionary progress can also be a return to positions that we may have archived too quickly—from Vachel Lindsay and Bela Balázs to Bazin and Bellour and well beyond. (2010, n.p.)

For Corrigan, modernity spans the sixteenth to the late twentieth centuries and is “the gateway to the emerging centrality of adaptation as a cultural and epistemological perspective”; following modernism, postmodernism brought about even “more fluid and pronounced versions of adaptation” (2017, 23). Even as Corrigan’s chapter traces a theoretical progress, it considers how “earlier terms and perspectives have resurfaced within contemporary debates and changing directions” (2017, 33) and his student readers reprint essays by older as well as newer scholars (1999; 2011). Cardwell, discussing Corrigan, concurs with him:

Adaptation studies would benefit from hitting “replay” and re-instituting a vital, energetic and ongoing engagement with its key terms and concepts. . . . Old definitions and debates will no longer do, but we must avoid throwing the baby out with the bathwater. (2018, 15–16)

Even progressive scholars understand the need for theoretical return in adaptation studies: Naremore’s *Film Adaptation* (2000a) contains not only cutting-edge progressive studies by Ray and Stam but also a 1948 essay by Bazin as well as Andrew’s 1984 essay on adaptation. In spite of their theoretical differences, Cartmell and Whelehan (2010) and MacCabe (2011) too have affirmed Bazin’s contributions to adaptation studies. For all the criticisms levied against heritage adaptations (Higson 2003; 2004; Voigts-Virchow 2004, and more), adaptation scholars remain interested in heritage *theories*, as do publishers, evidenced in Routledge’s 2013 five-volume series of “adaptation classics,” which reprints adaptation scholarship published from the 1940s to the 1990s.

“Post-” theories have not necessarily or unilaterally produced progress for theorizing adaptation; concomitantly, returning to earlier theories has not always been a regressive or reactionary move. Even the newer theories of the theoretical *turn* engage in theoretical *return*. These dynamics are articulated in the proliferation of post- and neo- prefixes attached to theoretical stem words, as in poststructuralism, postmodernism, posthumanism, postfeminism, and postcolonialism and neo-narratology, neo-Marxism, and neo-feminism. Both prefixes undertake operations akin to adaptation: both repeat aspects of the theories they vary to suit new academic and cultural environments. Undoubtedly, the theoretical adaptations of neo- and posttheorization have helped theories that might otherwise have become extinct to survive. Progress and return and repetition and variation, then, have

been essential not just to the survival of fictional stories but also to the survival of theoretical stories.

The 2000s and 2010s produced robust and expansive neo-theorization, which has often been neglected in progressivist histories that focus on posttheorization. Neo-theorization has tended to be less radical than posttheorization. When poststructuralism proved too formally radical for many structuralists, neo-structuralists were nevertheless persuaded that political and cultural issues need to be theorized, not just formal ones (Nünning 2003). Neo-formalists have also revisited and updated translation theories, pressing them beyond dyadic, comparative textual studies into multifarious con(text)ual, cross-cultural, intermedial, and/or polysystems analyses (Zatlin 2005; Chan 2012; Raw 2012; Krebs 2012; 2013; Cattrysse 2014; Smith 2016; Lee, Tan, and Stephens 2017). More specific to adaptation, the twenty-first century also produced neo-ekphrastic (Clüver 2017), neo-canonical (Szwedky 2018), neo-fidelity, neo-originality, and neo-medium specificity theories of adaptation that similarly complicated, nuanced, and sharpened prior theories. Kranz and Mellerski's *In/fidelity: Essays on Film Adaptation* (2008) rejects the binary in favor of a spectrum of essays on the subject ranging from traditional translation to radical poststructuralist approaches. The contributors to *True to the Spirit: Film Adaptation and the Question of Fidelity* (MacCabe et al. 2011) also span a theoretical spectrum. Casie Hermansson (2015), David T. Johnson (2017), and Dennis Cutchins and Kathryn Meeks (2018) have offered incisive metacritical discussions of fidelity debates that are a far cry from the simplistic "fidelity myth" discussed in Chapter 1 of this book. Similarly, scholars continue to ponder and retheorize complexly (rather than simply affirm or dismiss) originality in adaptation (Emig 2018; Jellenik 2018). Neo-medium specificity studies have also become more complex and nuanced. Arguing that if a particular formal feature can appear in two media, it cannot be specific to either, Lars Elleström devised new modes of media categorization that redress the essentialism of older theories via flexible material models that straddle many media and account for multimedial forms combining different media modalities untheorized by Lessing's binaries (Elleström 2010). Shannon Brownlee (2018) has pondered the challenges that digital media and identity politics present to medium specificity theory. Arguing that so-called essentialist media differences are culturally and technologically constructed just as so-called essentialist race, gender, age, and sexual differences are performed, Brownlee's chapter that "the modernist emphasis on ontology can give way to a postmodern emphasis on discourse

without requiring us to abandon the concept of medium altogether” (165). Following Mary Anne Doane in resisting poststructuralist deconstructions of media differences on political grounds, Brownlee’s argument is that such universal flattenings are culturally oppressive in failing to recognize and respect media and cultural differences (166). These and other twenty-first-century adaptation studies indicate that scholars still return to address the unresolved problems of older theories for adaptation—problems that post-theories have failed to resolve.

Individual scholars have also returned to reconsider prior theoretical positions. In a field that is itself continually adapting, adaptation scholars understand the necessity of both repeating and varying prior theoretical positions. In 2012, Leitch engaged in theoretical return, retracting his 2003 argument that intertextual theories would resolve the problems of adaptation studies under older formal theories, delineating their limitations for theorizing adaptation (2012a). Similarly, after Christine Geraghty championed contextual over formal adaptation study in 2007, in 2012 she returned to consider formal issues in her study of Charles Dickens’s *Bleak House* adapted to television.

Such hybrid temporality often allies to hybrid theoretical methodologies and principles, as in Hutcheon’s strange brew of postmodern indeterminacy and empirical methodologies. Leitch has straddled structuralist and poststructuralist theories productively, refusing both systematicity of the former and the dissipation of the latter. In 2018, he described his methodology as “empirical, particularistic, moving from observations about particular adapted and adapting texts to more general theories and back again, and ultimately unsystematic (perhaps even anti-systematic), intuitive, and playful” (Leitch and Cattrysse 2018, n.p.). Fredric Jameson has theorized adaptation using a blend of modernist medium specificity theory, high-art aestheticism, and poststructuralist Marxism (2011). Other adaptation scholars have moved productively between historicism, New Historicism, and postmodern ahistoricism. In 2017, Cartmell turned from her earlier interest in postmodern ahistoricity to a more traditional historical study: “Seventeen years later, it is apparent to me that the time of the adaptation is what we are interested in and that the context in which we place the adaptation should be within other adaptations (and other works) produced in the same period” (n.p.). For these and other scholars, myself included, theorizing *adaptively* means moving between older and newer theories that may not cohere logically, epistemologically, or methodologically with each other but may

explicate adaptation more satisfactorily than adherence to single theories or logically congruous ones.

Theoretical Lack, Theoretical Pluralism, Theoretical Abandonment

For Andrew, “adaptation feeds cultural studies, a discipline born for this era of proliferation, where textual contagion counts more than does interpretation” (2011, 28). Joining the postmodern expansion of adaptation studies to ever-widening media, disciplines, nations, and cultures, the twenty-first century witnessed a drive for widening participation in the *theories* applied to adaptation. This was the product not only of theoretical trends in the humanities but also of scholarly awareness that, because adaptation is itself pluralistic, it requires pluralistic theorization: “adaptation cannot and must not rely on one theory or even one clearly prescribed set of theories only. . . . [I]ts multi- and interdisciplinary status also determines its multi-, inter-, and transtheoretical attachments” (Emig 2012, 14).

For Westbrook, theoretical lack in adaptation studies is the result of adaptation’s vast macroscopic historical and temporal expanse and of its microscopic multiplicities. For this reason, “a grand unifying theory for adaptation studies is not, in fact, possible; the sheer volume of everything involved in a discussion of film adaptation is virtually immeasurable, which means that no one single theory has the capacity to encompass every aspect of an adaptation” (Westbrook 2010, 42). The best that scholars can do, his chapter argues, is to engage a postmodern theoretical pluralism, which has no hope of being able to account fully for the vast process that is adaptation, but will theorize it better than any other option.

Yet other scholars have objected to postmodern pluralism. Andrew’s epigraph to this section suggests that the theoretical pluralism of postmodern cultural studies lacks interpretive depth, pursuing proliferating expanse instead, and that it lacks cohesion, proceeding by a process of contagion rather than healthy growth. In 2010, Cartmell and Whelehan discussed the pleasures of postmodern pluralism in a rhetoric of theoretical promiscuity, celebrating “the excitement of encountering in every site of adaptation an entirely new set of relations which allows us to draw promiscuously on theoretical tendencies in film and literary studies” (22).

Even so, postmodern pluralism has introduced particular challenges for adaptation studies that do not appear in single disciplines. Whereas postmodern pluralism shattered hegemonic theories in established disciplines, rendered their centripetal forces centrifugal, toppling their monolithic canons, when postmodernism entered adaptation studies the field was already piecemeal, patchy, and sharded. Nor was postmodernism the only pluralist or interdisciplinary theory seeking to theorize adaptation. Scholars have worked to connect the field's shards and patches via structuralist narratology (McFarlane 1996), postmodern pastiche (Hutcheon 2006), dialogics (Stam 2000), intertextuality (Leitch 2003a), intermediality (Constantinescu 2015), and polysystems theories (Cattrysse 1992; 2014).

Pluralist theories do not agree. Although Cattrysse called adaptation studies to turn from individual to corpus studies, from single sources to multiple ones, and from author/auteur studies of particular adaptations to wider reception and industry studies through polysystems theory, commendably reintegrating textual and contextual adaptation studies rent asunder by both modernism and the theoretical turn, and calling the field to break from comparative case studies of paired works into methodological pluralism, his epistemologies and methodologies remain diametrically opposed to those of postmodern cultural studies. Katja Krebs has commended his theory of pluralism as a progress from postmodern pluralism:

While Hutcheon, Sanders, and Leitch, to name but a few, laid the groundwork which allowed Adaptation Studies to establish itself as a field of inquiry in its own right, Cattrysse moves the field into the next necessary stage: that of developing conceptual tools which stand the test of critical investigation. (Krebs, book jacket endorsement of Cattrysse 2014)

Both Cattrysse and Krebs were trained in Europe countries where theorization—in order to qualify *as* theorization—must engage systematic methodologies, empirical epistemologies, and logical critical thinking.

Recalling Welsh's critiques of the theoretical turn, albeit from an entirely different theoretical tradition, in 2014, Cattrysse attacked "high" theory as theory that "only dogs can hear" (32), pitting descriptive, empirical, corpus-based methodologies against philosophical, aesthetic, and political theories, arguing that "Knowledge is reliable if one can verify it empirically . . . if a statement of fact can be demonstrated as accurate, it can be accepted as true by everyone equally" (35). However, the facts that "everyone equally" can accept

as true (as universal truths) are not limited to empirical observations: in his scholarship, they include the value judgments of aesthetic and humanist theories. Continuing to promote “descriptive-explanatory” adaptation studies four years later, Cattrysse defended aesthetic “quality” as a valid criterion of judgment contiguous with and predicated on scientific evolutionary theory (2018, 52). Thus, even as he valuably opened adaptation studies to corpus *methodologies*, he closed down the corpus of *theories* and *epistemologies* permitted to theorize adaptation.

Postmodern pluralism recommends the opposite: engaging many theories, it refuses to systematize them logically, chronologically, or hierarchically, arguing that empiricism is neither objective nor factual, but is the subjective cultural construction of dominant groups, all the more deceptive and pernicious because it lays claim to fact and universality. Far from universal, shared truth, Westbrook called for a postmodern “glorious plurality” of theories that would allow critics to “choose from a candy store of available approaches: semiotics, feminist criticism, Russian Formalism, media studies—the whole menu” (2010, 43). His inclusion of Russian Formalism and invocation of “the whole menu” aligns him more with Hutcheon than with Cartmell and Whelehan in his theoretical ecumenism. However, the candy store metaphor implies that no theory is essential to a nutritionally balanced field and that all theories are dispensable. Moreover, such ecumenical optionality remains problematic not only for those whose theories of theorization require logic, empiricism, and systematicity to qualify as theorization but also for those whose theories are predicated upon opposing other theories deemed to be politically, ethically, and culturally pernicious. If for Cattrysse postmodern pluralist candy is frivolous and inessential, for Cartmell and Whelehan, some of the candy is decidedly bad for the field.

Developing adaptation studies as an interdisciplinary field cannot take the form of mandating universal agreement on epistemologies, values, ideologies, and methodologies or even agreement on what theorization is and should do: other fields do not require this to exist as fields, while the disciplinary, historical, and geographical range of adaptation studies renders universal agreement even more of an impossibility than in single disciplines. Yet development as a field does require *dialogue* between disciplines and theories, including dialogue between contesting forms of theoretical pluralism. Leitch and Cattrysse engaged in just such a debate, published by *Literature/Film Quarterly* in 2018. Concluding his remarks, Leitch recommended theoretical pluralism as a way to navigate theoretical differences:

In the absence of a single consensual theory, we [should] work toward a theory of theories . . . a grammar of theories seems like a less impossible goal than the dream of a common theory, and one that's likely to engage a wider array of scholars who don't necessarily agree about anything else. (Leitch 2018b, n.p.)

Leitch understood that the free-for-all advanced by postmodernism pluralism is not really free for scholars pursuing other kinds of pluralism. Positing a middle ground between postmodern arbitrariness and structuralist systematicity, "a theory of theories" requires a degree of metacritical analysis, while a "a grammar of theories" requires a degree of systematicity; even so, a system akin to grammar is more malleable and variable, more hospitable to change over time than the universally agreed-upon facts to which empirical systematicity lays claim. It allows for diversity and freedom at the same time as it creates structures that set theories in relation to each other like parts of speech in a sentence.

Joining theoretical pluralism, theoretical wars, and theoretical compromise, the 2010s have witnessed a movement toward theoretical abandonment. This is also a theoretical position—or rather, a range of theoretical positions. In 2011, MacCabe agreed with Westbrook that "the number of variables involved in any adaptation from the linguistic form of the novel or short story to a film's matters of expression approach infinity" (2011, 8). However, while Westbrook recommended postmodern theoretical pluralism as a response, MacCabe opted for theoretical abandonment: "There are thus no models of how to adapt in this volume" (2011, 8). The reference to "models" indicates that MacCabe's theory of theorization is prescriptive and practitioner-based ("how to adapt"), which he deems impossible in a field as microscopically and macroscopically vast as adaptation studies. However, he readily embraces auteur theories in his own adaptation study, and his opposition to prescriptive models of adaptation is partly predicated on the theories of originality and genius to which he subscribes.

In his conclusion to *The Oxford Handbook of Adaptation Studies*, wittily titled, "Against Conclusions: Petit Theories and Adaptation Studies," Leitch too has called adaptation studies to abandon its quest for "dogmas," "organizing principles," or "a set of solutions to consensual problems" to pursue "petit Theory," defined as "a series of working hypotheses . . . that might be true and might not . . . but help us think better" (2017c, 703–4). Like Hutcheon, Leitch has tied analytical methodologies to indeterminate philosophies to oppose

large-scale, synthetic theorization in favor small-scale, piecemeal theorization based in questions. Both have rejected fixed, final, definitive, or satisfying answers; in so doing, both promote an adaptive theory of theorization. But there are differences between the two. While for Hutcheon the questions Who? What? Why? How? Where? remain constant, with the variable, eclectic answers providing the variation, for Leitch the chief value of answers is as springboards to new questions. Both Hutcheon's repetition of the same questions in varied environments and Leitch's incremental adaptation of theorization via Q&A produce adaptive theorization that adapts theorization to and through adaptation. Yet Hutcheon's methodology is more concerned with answers, while Leitch's is more concerned with questions.

Conclusion to the History

In 2014, Patrick Cattrysse referred readers to prior field histories rather than write one himself, while critiquing prior histories as incomplete: "No one can claim . . . to have studied all publications ever published in the field" (2014, 21–22). All histories must be partial, in both senses of the word—incomplete and reflecting the partialities of their authors. The actual history of theorizing adaptation reaches much farther back than mine and will continue after it; it is spread more widely across nations, cultures, disciplines, and media than mine, and extends beyond the particular research questions that have informed it. But the partial nature of all histories should not be grounds for refusing to write histories. All fields benefit from multiple, constantly rewritten, *adapting* histories. New histories not only keep a field up to date but also redress the omissions, distortions, and errors of prior histories. In fact, the worst outcome of my history of theorizing adaptation would be if it were to be treated as a final, definitive history. More histories of theorizing adaptation are needed—multiple histories that debate with and build on prior ones.

History is essential to understanding adaptation's relationship to theorization for many reasons, not the least of which is that it shows theorization to be historically contingent rather than universal. A history of theorizing adaptation underscores how much particular, local political, cultural, economic, industrial, and academic institutions affect and employ theorization for their agendas; concomitantly, it identifies transhistorical dynamics that do not emerge in localized historical studies. It also identifies theoretical

changes and theoretical alliances for adaptation that do not emerge in studies governed by a single theory.

This history has challenged humanities histories of theorizing adaptation that chart a march of theoretical progress: it tells a story of theoretical return—of theories that have refused to die, of theories that seemed to be extinct but reappeared like recessive genes decades or centuries on. It locates these processes not to complain of the failure of scholars to progress but to highlight the ways in which theorization has failed adaptation and in which scholars have adapted theorization to the returns and progresses of adaptation itself. Similarly, this history suggests that adaptation's own pluralism has attracted pluralist theorization (Andrew 2011, 28), and that even calls for theoretical abandonment may express adaptation's own blithe abandonment of theoretical principles.

This history of theorizing adaptation has also focused on the rising and falling theoretical fortunes of adaptation. A history of theorizing adaptation in earlier centuries, when adaptation was theorized as a good theoretical object, is illuminating for theorizing adaptation more positively now; even a history of how adaptation became a bad theoretical object reveals ways to theorize adaptation more constructively, serving as a cautionary tale for scholars today.

The transhistorical resistances of adaptation and theorization in this history suggest that there are larger systemic problems between the processes of adaptation and theorization in the humanities. This conclusion to the history therefore calls for another perspective, another mode of discourse to probe them further. The title of this history, "Theorizing Adaptation," articulates a one-way, top-down process in which adaptation is "-ized" by theories, a hierarchy that has not been sufficiently redressed by the philosophical skepticism and cultural revolutions of the theoretical turn. Part II of this book, therefore, works to invert the hierarchy that is "Theorizing Adaptation" with a reciprocal, inverse discourse of "Adapting Theorization" that calls humanities theorization to adapt to and through adaptation.